

There are millions of different species living on Earth. In fact, there are so many we have hardly started counting them all. Scientists think there could be anything between 2 and 100 million, although the current best estimate is 8.7 million. Out of these, only 1.8 million have been named and described.



MAMMOTH



ELEPHANT

The elephant's trunk is actually a combined nose and upper lip that lengthened over the course of millions of years as its incisor teeth grew larger and turned into tusks. With such large tusks they needed a long trunk to be able to reach food easily. Those with the longest trunks survived best.

How many of each?

The largest number of named species belongs to the animal kingdom. This is followed by plants, fungi, and protists. We can only guess at the number of bacteria species but they probably run into *millions*.



Animals 1,471,428



Plants 307,674



Fungi and protists 51,623

End of the line

When the last of a species dies out it is said to be extinct. Extinction is a natural event—around 99 percent of the species that have ever lived on Earth are extinct. Most extinctions go unnoticed, but there have been five occasions in history when a large number of species were wiped out at the same time. These were the result of natural events—asteroids hitting Earth, extreme volcanic eruptions, or climate change. Scientists think we are now losing species so fast that we are facing a new extinction event caused by habitat loss, pollution, and hunting. This time the blame lies closer to home—human activity.



New species

Discoveries of new species are being made every year. In 2006 alone, it was estimated that 50 new species were being reported every day. The majority of these are small invertebrates, although a surprising number of mammals, amphibians, and reptiles are also found. There are also many species we already know about that need to be properly classified and named. It takes time to work out whether something really is new or simply a variation of an existing species.



This giant woolly rat was discovered on an expedition to Papua New Guinea in 2009.

